ONE-OFF SHIURIM

What Is a Miracle?

Derech Hashem, Maamar HaIkarim

Sefer: Maamar HaIkarim by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal), printed at the end of Derech Hashem **Section:** Maamar HaIkarim, essay 9: miracles **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 18 July 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The penultimate essay: nature exists because God wills it

The group reached the ninth of the ten essays, on miracles, a subject studied before in the main book. The tenth, on the Oral Law, is entirely new. The plan was to finish by Tisha BeAv and break until September.

The Ramhal writes that all creations exist only because God wills them to exist, and so do all the laws that govern them. Just as God made the creatures and the laws of nature, He can cancel or change them whenever He wishes. Something He does that departs from the laws of nature is what we call a miracle.

The Rabbi recalled the meaning of nes. It means a banner. In the parashah just read, Moshe is told to place the copper serpent al nes, on a pole, so that everyone looks up to it. A miracle is a public sign, a banner, of God's involvement in the world.

Wonders are not miracles

The Rabbi drew a sharp line. The laws of nature, such as the sun, the moon, gravity and air resistance, may be amazing and a sign of God, but they are nature. A nes is something that goes against them. Water flowing is nature; water standing as a wall when the sea split is a miracle. The sun rising and setting every day is nature, however wonderful; the sun standing still for Yehoshua is a miracle.

A participant described a rabbi who, as a doctor, was so struck by the processes of childbirth that he changed his life. The Rabbi agreed this is incredible, like a seed becoming a tree, but said it is not the definition of a miracle, because it happens every time. "Nes means something which is unlike the daily activities." The oil of Hanukkah lasting eight days was a miracle.

Most of the time, says the Ramhal, God wants nature to continue as it is, since that is how He made the world. Yet He does not hold back from changing it for reasons He knows.

Why miracles happen, and through whom

Sometimes God performs a miracle because it is necessary, as when Israel fled Egypt and needed the sea to split. Sometimes it is to show that He is present. The Rabbi's example was

Hanukkah: the people could have managed without the menorah for seven nights, but God showed He was still with them. Some miracles are open to everyone, like the splitting of the sea; others are hidden, and some have no reason we can see.

God also lets those close to Him act as conduits for His miracles, to show His love for them and the power He gives them over creation, each according to his closeness. The sun stopping was done directly by God. The sea was split through Moshe, though God did not need him, so that "they believed in God and in Moshe His servant".

Miracles through the Divine names

The Ramhal adds that God chose to be called by different names, matching the different flows of His influence in the world, and that by mentioning these holy names many wonders can be brought about. The Rabbi linked this to the chapter in the main book on God's names. There are miracles that come from above, where God instructs Moshe to stretch out his arm. And there are miracles that start from below, where people use the system God created. All of this requires great wisdom and great closeness to God.

The Rambam: miracles are built into nature

A participant asked whether miracles were set up at the beginning of creation. The Rabbi explained this is a debate between the Ramhal and the Rambam. For the Rambam there is no miracle in the sense of something new that breaks nature. When God created the world, He built into the sea's nature that at a certain point in history it would split. It is unusual, but it is part of nature from creation. For the Ramhal, there are laws of nature, and every so often God intervenes, either by His own decision or because people stir Him, and He has created ways for us to change nature.

"Two very different ways of looking at the world." One sees the world as more enchanted: you say a name and something happens. The other is more straightforward: God planted in the six days of creation certain moments when things would behave differently from what we expect.

The participant pointed to the Mishnah's ten things created at twilight on the eve of the first Shabbat, such as the rainbow and the mouth of Bilam's donkey. The Rabbi said the Rambam indeed uses this as a proof. But the Rambam also says the donkey did not really speak and it all happened in Bilam's mind, which the Rabbi finds difficult, since the Mishnah lists the mouth of the donkey among those created things.

Miracle or charisma?

A participant raised the story of Elisha feeding many people with a small amount of food. The Rabbi suggested such stories often have a kernel of truth, but not every one is a miracle. A charismatic leader who reassures hungry people that a little food will be enough may genuinely satisfy them; perhaps that was psychological. By contrast, a miracle of Elisha in which the supply kept on refilling clearly defies nature. Asked about Pharaoh's magicians turning water into blood, he said they either had real powers or were playing tricks. Asked whether anyone present had seen an outright miracle, he said, "I don't think we see these things anymore."

He invited suggestions for a short, light book to learn after the summer, mentioning Hovot HaLevavot as one option.

Summary

- A miracle, a nes, is a public "banner" of God's involvement that goes against the laws of nature.
- Amazing natural processes such as childbirth are wonders, not miracles, because they happen all the time.
- God performs miracles when necessary, to show His presence, or to honour those close to Him, who can act as conduits.
- The Ramhal sees miracles as God's intervention in nature, sometimes stirred by people using His names.
- The Rambam holds miracles were built into nature at creation.

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